



ARIN PUBLISHING ACADEMY

Research Writing, Publishing, and Policy Communication for African Scholars

MODULE 1: ACADEMIC WRITING MASTERY

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SESSION 3:

JOURNAL SELECTION AND SUBMISSION READINESS



TOPICS



Identifying
suitable journals



Impact factors and
journal rankings



Avoiding
journal mismatch



Submission
checklists



Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Select an appropriate journal for their manuscript.
2. Interpret journal quality indicators and indexing databases.
3. Avoid common reasons for journal rejection.
4. Prepare a complete, submission-ready manuscript.

Identifying suitable journals

Choosing the right journal is one of the most important decisions in the publication process.

A well-written manuscript can still be rejected if it is submitted to a journal that does not align with its scope, audience, or publication requirements.



Before submission, evaluate these factors to ensure appropriate fit for your research.

Considerations	Why It Matters
1. Journal Scope	The journal must publish research related to your topic and discipline. Editors often reject manuscripts that fall outside the journal's scope before peer review.
2. Target Audience	Publishing in a journal read by your intended audience increases the visibility and impact of your research.
3. Article Type	Journals publish different types of manuscripts and may not accept all study designs.
4. Journal Quality and Reputation	Publishing in reputable journals improves the credibility, discoverability and impact of your work.
5. Publication Speed	Review and publication times vary considerably among journals.
6. Open Access and Publication Costs	Some journals charge Article Processing Charges (APCs), while others publish free of charge or offer fee waivers.
7. Likelihood of Acceptance	Selecting a journal that matches the quality and novelty of your manuscript improves the chances of acceptance.
8. Author Guidelines	Every journal has specific formatting and submission requirements. Failure to follow them may result in desk rejection.

Understanding journal ratings

- Journal quality indicators help authors evaluate the visibility, credibility and influence of a journal.
- While no single metric should determine where to publish, understanding these indicators enables researchers to make informed decisions about selecting appropriate journals for their work.
- Journal metrics are useful indicators of visibility and influence, but they should never replace the most important consideration: whether the journal is the right fit for your manuscript.
- A well-matched paper published in a reputable, appropriately targeted journal is far more likely to be read, cited and have real-world impact than one submitted solely because of a high metric.

Metric	What It Measures	Why It Matters	When to Use	Example
Impact Factor (IF)	The average number of citations received by articles published in a journal during the previous two years.	Indicates how frequently articles in the journal are cited, reflecting its influence within a field.	Useful when comparing journals within the same discipline. Should not be the only selection criterion.	A journal with an IF of 6.2 means its articles received, on average, about six citations during the two-year calculation period.
CiteScore	The average number of citations received over the previous four years. Calculated using the Scopus database.	Covers a longer citation period than the Impact Factor and often includes more document types.	Particularly useful when comparing journals indexed in Scopus.	A journal with a CiteScore of 8.5 averages about 8.5 citations per published document over four years.
SCImago Journal Rank (SJR)	Measures both the number of citations and the prestige of the journals providing those citations.	Recognizes that citations from highly respected journals contribute more than citations from less influential journals.	Useful for comparing journals across different disciplines and evaluating journal prestige.	Two journals may receive the same number of citations, but the one cited by more prestigious journals will have a higher SJR.
Quartile Ranking (Q1–Q4)	Ranks journals within their subject category based on citation performance.	Provides a quick indication of a journal's standing relative to others in the same field.	Helpful when selecting journals of similar scope.	Q1 journals are in the top 25% of their field, while Q4 journals are in the lowest 25%.
H-index	Measures the long-term productivity and citation impact of a journal.	Reflects sustained influence over time rather than short-term citation performance.	Useful for assessing the journal's long-term reputation and consistency.	A journal with an H-index of 120 has published at least 120 articles that have each been cited at least 120 times.

How Should Authors Use Journal Metrics?

Journal metrics should **inform**, not determine, your journal selection. Before submitting a manuscript, consider the following questions:

- Is the journal reputable and peer-reviewed?
- Is it indexed in major databases such as Scopus, PubMed or Web of Science?
- Does it reach the audience most likely to use my research?
- Is its level of influence appropriate for my study?
- Does it have reasonable publication timelines and costs?

Metrics should always be considered **alongside** journal scope, audience, indexing, publication costs and author guidelines.

Common Misconceptions on Journal Rankings/Impact

MISCONCEPTION	REALITY
The journal with the highest Impact Factor is always the best choice.	The best journal is the one that best matches your research topic, audience and study design.
A Q1 journal guarantees acceptance.	Q1 journals are highly competitive and have low acceptance rates.
Impact Factor measures article quality.	It measures average journal citations, not the quality of individual papers.
Journals with lower metrics are poor quality.	Many specialized and regional journals publish excellent research and reach highly relevant audiences.
One metric is enough to judge a journal.	Journal quality is best assessed using multiple metrics together with scope, indexing and reputation.

Avoiding Journal Mismatch

1. **Read the "Aims and Scope" first:** If your study does not align with the journal's focus, it is likely to be rejected without peer review.
2. **Review recently published articles:** Look at the last 10 papers published by the journal.
Ask:
 - a. Are they similar to my topic?
 - b. Do they use similar study designs?
 - c. Is my manuscript of comparable quality?
3. **Match your study design:** Ensure the journal accepts your type of manuscript, whether it is an RCT, qualitative study, systematic review, implementation study, or protocol.
4. **Think beyond the Impact Factor:** A journal with a lower Impact Factor but the right audience often results in greater visibility and citation than a high-impact journal that is a poor fit.
5. **Follow the author guidelines exactly:** Editors expect manuscripts to comply with formatting, reporting standards, word limits, and reference styles. Careful adherence demonstrates professionalism and can prevent unnecessary desk rejection.

Predatory Journals

A **predatory journal** is a publication that prioritizes collecting publication fees over conducting legitimate peer review, editorial oversight, and ethical publishing.

These journals often promise rapid publication but fail to meet accepted scientific publishing standards.

If a journal promises publication that seems too easy or too fast, pause and verify its credibility

Consequences of Publishing in Predatory Journals

Publishing in predatory journals can have serious consequences:

- Your research may not be recognized by universities or funding agencies.
- The article may not be indexed or easily discoverable.
- Your work is less likely to be cited.
- You may lose publication fees without receiving legitimate editorial services.
- Your academic reputation may be affected.

RED FLAGS OF PREDATORY JOURNALS

WARNING SIGN	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
1 Unsolicited Invitations	Unexpected emails inviting you to submit a manuscript or join the editorial board, especially outside your area of expertise.
2 Guaranteed or Rapid Publication	Promises of acceptance or publication within a few days, with little or no peer review.
3 Misleading Metrics	Use of fake or unfamiliar impact metrics instead of recognized measures such as the Impact Factor or SJR.
4 Not Properly Indexed	Claims to be indexed but cannot be found in trusted databases such as Scopus, Web of Science, PubMed, or DOAJ.
5 Poor Website Quality	Broken links, spelling and grammar errors, missing policies, or an unprofessional website.
6 Unclear Peer Review	No clear explanation of the peer-review or editorial process.
7 Hidden Publication Fees	Article Processing Charges (APCs) are disclosed only after the manuscript has been accepted.
8 Questionable Editorial Board	Editors have no verifiable affiliations or appear unrelated to the journal's field.
9 Overly Broad Scope	The journal claims to publish on almost every subject with no clear disciplinary focus.
10 Missing Publisher Information	No verifiable publisher name, physical address, or contact information.

Tools for finding suitable journals and avoiding Predatory Journals

These online tools help researchers identify journals that match their manuscript based on the title, abstract, keywords, or research area. The tools save time and improve selection of appropriate journals.

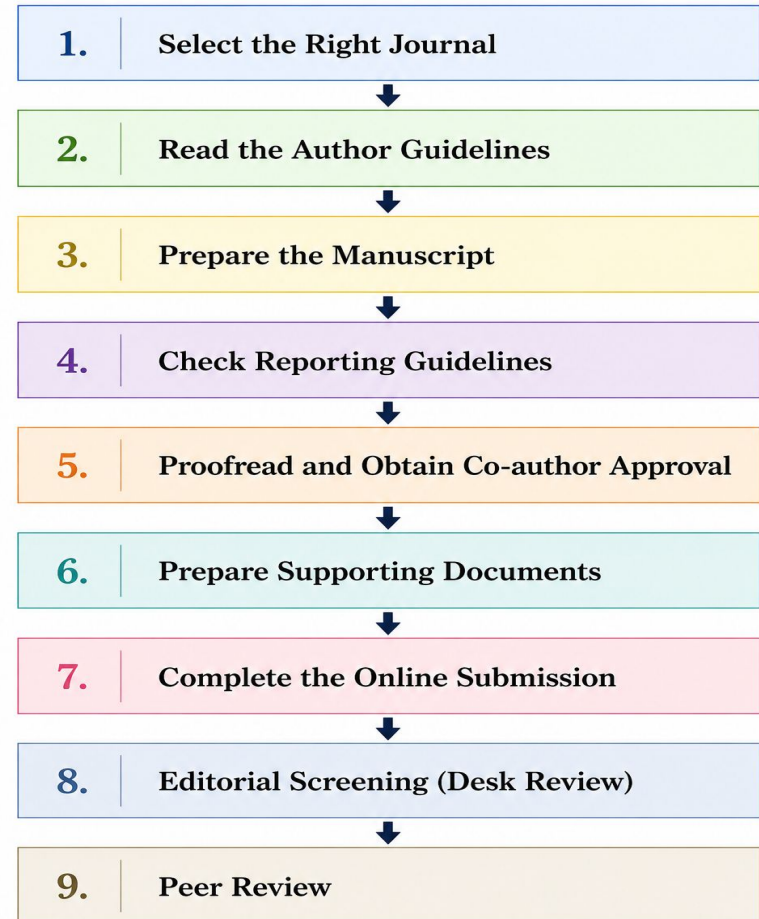
Tool	Purpose	How It Works	Best For
Jane (Journal/Author Name Estimator)	Recommends journals based on your manuscript.	Paste your title or abstract; JANE searches similar articles in PubMed and suggests matching journals.	Medicine, Public Health, Nursing, Biomedical Sciences
Elsevier Journal Finder	Identifies suitable Elsevier journals.	Uses your manuscript title, abstract and keywords to recommend journals.	Multidisciplinary research published by Elsevier
Springer Nature Journal Suggester	Matches manuscripts to Springer Nature journals.	Analyzes your title and abstract to recommend the best fit.	Health Sciences, Natural Sciences, Social Sciences
Wiley Journal Finder	Suggests journals within Wiley's portfolio.	Matches manuscript content with relevant Wiley journals.	Health, Life Sciences, Education and Social Sciences
SCImago Journal & Country Rank	Compares journal quality and rankings.	Search journals by discipline to view SJR, Quartile ranking (Q1–Q4) and H-index.	Comparing journal quality and selecting high-impact journals
Master Journal List	Verifies journal indexing and credibility.	Search by journal title or ISSN to confirm Web of Science indexing.	Confirming reputable, indexed journals before submission

Manuscript submission

The Submission Workflow is a step-by-step process that ensures your manuscript is complete, compliant, and ready for publication.

- It begins with selecting the right journal and carefully following its author guidelines, then preparing and refining the manuscript, checking reporting standards, obtaining co-author approval, and assembling all required supporting documents.
- Once submitted, the manuscript undergoes editorial screening before progressing to peer review.
- Following this workflow minimizes avoidable errors, reduces the risk of desk rejection, and improves the likelihood of successful publication.

The Submission Workflow



Manuscript submission checklist

Many manuscripts are rejected before peer review not because the science is weak, but because authors fail to follow the journal's submission requirements.

A thorough pre-submission review improves professionalism, reduces unnecessary delays, and increases the likelihood of successful peer review

PRE-SUBMISSION CHECKLIST

— Use this checklist to ensure your manuscript is complete, compliant, and submission-ready. —

CHECKPOINT	WHAT TO CHECK	STATUS
1. JOURNAL FIT	Does the manuscript fit the journal's scope and target audience?	☐
2. AUTHOR GUIDELINES	Have you followed the journal's instructions for authors, including word limits, formatting and reference style?	☐
3. MANUSCRIPT STRUCTURE	Does the manuscript contain all required sections (Title, Abstract, Introduction, Methods, Results, Discussion, Conclusion, References)?	☐
4. REPORTING GUIDELINES	Have you followed the appropriate reporting guideline (e.g., CONSORT, STROBE, PRISMA, COREQ)?	☐
5. LANGUAGE AND WRITING QUALITY	Has the manuscript been proofread for grammar, spelling and clarity?	☐
6. TABLES AND FIGURES	Are all tables and figures correctly labelled, cited in the text and submitted in the required format?	☐
7. REFERENCES	Are all references complete, accurate and formatted correctly?	☐
8. ETHICAL REQUIREMENTS	Have you included ethics approval, informed consent and conflict of interest statements where required?	☐
9. AUTHOR INFORMATION	Have all authors approved the final manuscript and agreed on the order of authorship?	☐
10. COVER LETTER	Have you prepared a tailored cover letter explaining why the manuscript is suitable for the journal?	☐

Documents Commonly Required During Submission

Document	Purpose
Manuscript	Main research article.
Title Page	Author names, affiliations, corresponding author details and acknowledgements.
Cover Letter	Introduces the manuscript and explains its importance and fit for the journal.
Tables and Figures	Submitted separately if required by the journal.
Supplementary Files	Additional methods, datasets or appendices.
Ethical Approval	Evidence of ethics committee approval where applicable.
Conflict of Interest Statement	Declares any competing interests.
Funding Statement	Acknowledges financial support received.
Author Contribution Statement	Describes each author's contribution to the research.
Reporting Checklist	Required by many journals (e.g., CONSORT, PRISMA, STROBE).

THE MANUSCRIPT REVIEW AND DECISION FLOW

Understanding the Path from Submission to Decision



Responding to Reviewer Comments

Rejection is Normal - Even experienced researchers often have rejection rates exceeding 50%. A rejected manuscript does not necessarily indicate poor research.



BEFORE YOU START

Read all reviewer comments carefully.

Reflect—avoid emotional reactions.

Focus on improving manuscript quality.



WHILE REVISING

Address every reviewer and editor comment systematically.

Prepare a detailed point-by-point response table showing:
(Reviewer comment
| Your response |
Change location)



IF YOU DISAGREE

Do not ignore the comment.

Explain your scientific rationale respectfully with evidence.

Maintain professional, constructive tone.



IF YOU NEED CLARIFICATION

Contact the journal editor if a reviewer comment is unclear.

Common Reasons for Rejection

- Journal scope mismatch.
- Limited novelty.
- Weak study design.
- Insufficient sample size.
- Poor statistical analysis.
- Weak discussion.

Finally...

If you decide not to proceed with a revised submission after receiving reviewers' comments, it is good academic practice to inform the journal editor of your decision rather than leaving the manuscript unresolved.

Take-Home Exercise

In preparation for the next modules. Finetune your abstracts, introduction and methods section (3 pages)

Questions

Feedback

**Thank
you for
Participating**



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